

Dec 3, 2025

Michael and Vin continuation - Transcript

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Vinnie Micciche: Hello.

Michael Donovan: What's going on?

Vinnie Micciche: Hold on. Let me just shut my door.

Michael Donovan: Yep.

Vinnie Micciche: Listen, I know you're um sick. um for our both both of our healths like this has got to stop. I didn't threaten your job or try to fire you. What I said was we can't continue like this. That's what I said. You started saying that I'm putting you in putting, you know, pinning you in a hole or something like that. That's what got me upset. I'm not I don't work that way. I'm very just direct and transparent. All I can tell you is I don't know. I don't I can't read your mind. I don't know what you do all day long. I know what I see. And you don't seem to translate what I'm asking for into like some type of way that you can say, "Okay, here's what I'm working on. Here's what you can expect." I don't ever know that.

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Vinnie Micciche: I put that document together. Yes, I put Jason and I on because I think we both based on the the content that I've seen Ken and now that I I have seen from uh Z, I feel like I need to be I don't want surprises where s***'s going out there and I'm not happy with it.

Michael Donovan: I I I hear you. I agree. I've I started in this business in in an indirect way. 2005 when I left the mortgage industry.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm.

Michael Donovan: My buddy had an independent shop. There was some shady s*** going on at the mortgage business. I didn't agree with it. Okay.

Vinnie Micciche: I've been I did mortgages in a shady place too for a year and a half back in Yep.

Michael Donovan: So, I left. Oh, yeah. You can look look this. The guy's name was Dave Silipino. Okay. \$5 million from Bears and Sterns disappeared in 1999 with his first company. Faced federal charges. He never went to jail.

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Michael Donovan: He got his buddy to open up this new shop called First Guarantee Mortgage. Probably like 6 five 600 of us.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm.

Michael Donovan: We were all 20 to 30 years old. I I mean, dude, I had a Navigator, uh, an Acura Integra, a motorcycle, a a closet full of \$2,000 suits, and my rent was 200 bucks a month cuz I had two roommates, two buddies of mine, and we all worked there and it was wild. But the it was fraud. on one of my deals, I was I was a uh a mentor.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm.

Michael Donovan: So, I had like a small team within the team and my direct manager was engaged to, you know, one of the hot shots, Matt Hickey, who was like Dave's little, you know, yes man. He'd follow him around. So, one of my deals, never forget it, Shauna and Kevin Hesseline, they were in Chapter 13 bankruptcy.

Vinnie Micciche: Yep. Yep.

Michael Donovan: They sent their docs in their uh debt to income was it wasn't even a full percentage point over the threshold but we had submitted it.

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Michael Donovan: It got declined. So, it's a dead deal while my manager who was engaged to this, you know, old hot shot guy, Matt Hickey, um, she freaking forged it.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah. Yeah.

Michael Donovan: Like two weeks later, it's up on the board to close. Set to close. She's like, "You need to call customer set." Like, what? How?

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah.

Michael Donovan: Just do it. Well, I do deal closes and we used Kaix Point was like the software and we could go in and look at the closing docks. And I looked at the freaking closing docks. I went through them. I had my copy and she took one of the affirmed liabilities and freaking included it in the bankruptcy.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah.

Michael Donovan: She forged freaking court documents.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah, I used to say the same thing when I was doing

Michael Donovan: So, So, I left, man. And I I I didn't know what I was going to do, but my buddy had this independent shop and we all rode.

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Michael Donovan: We all rode our, you know, crotch rockets, right? And I turned wrenches. I did tires. I did lube oil filter. I did intake gaskets, head gaskets. We'd swap engines. I rebuilt a a 1000cc inline four cylinder uh motorcycle engine, you know, micrflux the crankshaft, pistons, rings, had it punched, new sleeves. So, that's how I actually started in the automotive industry. And you know, like your story, selling at Sears, coupon books.

Vinnie Micciche: Yep.

Michael Donovan: Okay. Well, in ' 07, that's when I got into marketing and I became infatuate just like it was for me rebuilding that engine. That's how I'm wired. I'm a I'm a I'm a system solution. I want to know how things work. And you know, that even traces back to when I took the

Vinnie Micciche: I think I think what the problem isn't that I I respect that you like that stuff. The challenge what I think you have is that you owned your own agency and then you come in here and you know we're struggling.

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Vinnie Micciche: Uh we we've done marketing a certain way. You know it's changed. I get it. I want to change with it. But there are certain fundamental things that worked for us before that we stopped doing. And um I keep hearing about this engine you're building, but like it's not translating into any type of actionable opportunities, you know, and Sean Reigns and I had this conversation four three years ago. Like we built the whole business on reputation.

Michael Donovan: I

Vinnie Micciche: I mean, you see leads come through still where it says referral. Like I'm not sure that we can generate leads, but we have and the la you have to admit the last four months has been really scary. And I don't see any action.

Michael Donovan: I I don't disagree with that.

Vinnie Micciche: Keep hearing about keep hearing about a new site. Like I'm not even sure the site is a problem as much as you know just regular posting, email campaigns, whatever it was that we were doing before that we need to kind of get going.

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Vinnie Micciche: And I know you had Z. Um, listen. I I did I handle Z the right way. I didn't handle Z the wrong way. You want to constantly You and Joe do this to me all the time. You want to constantly give me your resume and tell me I already know your I wouldn't have hired you if I didn't think you were You don't have You got to stop with telling me all the stuff you know and everything and just listen. I do have some, you know, like when you I I send you the um the lovable thing and you start telling me all the reasons why it's more complex. It's it's fine. I didn't expect that to be turned into a f***** website. But what I did expect you to appreciate was the amount of information I was able to send you in less than an hour and build a page to give you some ideas on what I liked and what I

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: didn't read into it.

Michael Donovan: So again, I I'm Yeah, but yeah.

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Vinnie Micciche: It's like you have this you have imposter syndrome worse than me. It's like you've been beat up so much that you got to prove yourself all the time. I'm just give throwing s*** at you and it doesn't always translate back to me the way I'm I'm sending it out to you though. You know what I mean? Like I I I did this one specifically. That was the 10th one it gave me because I would love to attract dealer groups.

Michael Donovan: No, I know.

Vinnie Micciche: As a matter of fact, Catchy BT is telling me to stop going after these small mom and pops because that's where all our turns coming from and they don't they're not into security and structure and and scalability and groups are.

Michael Donovan: Yeah, I've seen I've experienced that.

Vinnie Micciche: But the challenge the challenge with that for in the past was we didn't have the ability to scale for a group.

Michael Donovan: Look, man.

Vinnie Micciche: So, we didn't go after that. But we're starting to, you know, talk about products and services that we can potentially scale.

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Vinnie Micciche: Um, and so we need to start thinking like that. That's why I use that one first because I know we don't. Basically what it said is here's 10 things that you're not doing that you need to do to attract the LLMs. That's the important part. All the details again, I get it. might be more more complicated than that, but I mean I would have to have you I would have to question your intelligence to be quite honest with you because it's the most amazing tool I've come across and I've

Michael Donovan: So, I'm I'm not like an anti-lovable, you know? I actually spent time prompting this to get the logo.

Vinnie Micciche: been using all of them.

Michael Donovan: No. Okay. So it's well I just interpreted what you said as like all the things wrong.

Vinnie Micciche: You said I'm not anti-lovable. I mean, I never said that you were

Michael Donovan: I'm not saying anything's wrong with I think it's a great thing because it fills a major gap where you can put your ideas have a visual and you know it's the visual isn't can be interpreted by someone like Sergey or someone technical as documentation.

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Vinnie Micciche: Mhm.

Michael Donovan: So, and documentation documentation's minimum requirements. This is super important. You know, we're not we're not doing PRDs.

Vinnie Micciche: Yep.

Michael Donovan: We're not doing minimum requirements. You know, I picked up on that pretty early on. We had a meeting about I thought it was something based on my experience where I may be able to help. It was on January 3rd. I have a stupid memory. So, look, let's talk about the solution, right?

Vinnie Micciche: All I'm trying to say is forget about the solutions for a second.

Michael Donovan: the solution.

Vinnie Micciche: We need to we need to make sure we can work together and you need

to you need to start listening to what I'm saying to you.

Michael Donovan: That's what I'm saying.

Vinnie Micciche: Not hearing me. I mean not listening to me but hearing me. I am so like buddy honestly I'm so tired right now because I haven't stopped talking all day. I never realized how much how draining talking all day is but like I don't like I need people around me like you and Joe and Shauna and Jason to feed me like what's important, not every f***** thing.

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Vinnie Micciche: And so when I tell you what's important to me and then you ignore it, that's frustrating to me because I don't have if I'm telling you that means it's really important to me. You know what I'm saying? I wouldn't I because I'm I'm not telling you everything I want from marketing.

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: I'm telling you a few specific things that I need. The reason I reached out to Christina so quickly is because I knew she did the newsletter. I know she's trying to start her own job. You mentioned her. Shauna mentioned her two weeks ago.

Michael Donovan: Heat.

Vinnie Micciche: And I'm like, like, is that the right solution? Should we go find somebody, you know, more qualified and all this other stuff? It's a good solution right now because she you she's going to require no ramp and really very little training.

Michael Donovan: I I would have to take a look at my LinkedIn history, but it was around the time like somewhere around the beginning of beginning to mid October, I messaged her.

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Michael Donovan: I had recognized like this guy is an issue. Something's off with Z. And I was I was trying to be proactive, man.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm. Yeah.

Michael Donovan: And you know, I I just want to level set on a couple of things. This is this is what I had gone over this with Z before he started. Okay. So, I just outlined some of the internal like the newsletter, the all hands meeting, off any off-site meetings if we need to provide material agenda or any planning, team building, TBD, trade shows

primarily once a year. And then if anything for swag or soft goods, it seemed like it was about twice a year. Then our our marketing Google we have SEO AIO or they're GEO now search generative Google ads YouTube right weekly weekly twice a month social channels daily daily develop new channels Tik Tok first 60 days Reddit first 90 days website management SEO landing p like all of this is outlined with the frequency and then we even had covered some some uh email marketing right for the CRM management on any unsold prospects how we can nurture and come up with a schedule and tracking and optimize optimization and what you've heard me talking about is is the account-based marketing and the intentbased marketing and then Even with onboarding supporting Jason and team and client success and operations obviously

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Vinnie Micciche: I know. But you one of the problems you have is a similar very it's very common um is that you you talk a lot about all the things you want to do, but you're not quantifying the amount of time it's going to take to do it all. and then prioritize what can be done now and and give up on some of the things that are great ideas but you just don't have the time for. And that's what I mean by you owned your own business. I know the cash flow situation here and the structure and what we can afford and can't afford. So I'm I just had this meeting. I wish you were on it. I for the last five years did not b**** at my management team for not getting more involved with dealers, not getting more involved with agents, not getting more involved with customers because I knew all the busy work that they had to do. So, what we've done over the last six or seven months is clear away a lot of their busy work.

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Vinnie Micciche: Now, they need to do the important stuff. What's the important stuff? Building relationships with their employees, with the with the dealers, and with the customers.

Michael Donovan: right?

Vinnie Micciche: Because if you're not good at that, there's nothing left for you to do in the future when AI does all the f***** busy work for you. It's the important s***. And so you have a lot I know. I just can't get my head around like I told you I prior I prioritize

around, you know, employee satisfaction, dealer satisfaction, and customer experience. And with marketing, I rely on you to prioritize profit is the fourth one.

Michael Donovan: Right.

Vinnie Micciche: you and Jason are are solely responsible for helping to drive revenue in here. Uh or at least keep us fresh and new so people think about us when they're looking to make a decision on a problem that we can solve for. So with that said, that's what I'm thinking about for marketing and you're telling me about all these other things and I'm having trouble understanding why is, you know, why is Michael not hearing me?

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Vinnie Micciche: It's because you have your mind in other places. That may not align with what what I have. And it it it doesn't mean that you're wrong. It just means you just said it. You're drowning over there. You said it earlier. You got a lot of s*** going on. I get it. So, what do we what do we knock off one by one that can make an impact and help, you know, grow the company that helps our employees? It helps our dealers. It helps our, you know, customers when we can invest more in technology and build and grow the company. Like revenue, that's what it is. like and we're not getting leads. So, that's how my brain works. That's how I that's how I chunk it down. Of course, there's I told you before I swore off consultants because all they do is come in and tell me all the things that I need to fix that I already know. I just don't have the resources to fix them.

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Vinnie Micciche: This is a very labor human intensive operation. And you know the margins we got up to somewhere around 45% margins which is almost unheard of in a call center because it's usually much heavier labor but we've been doing it with technology and we're continuing to chop away at it. Our people need to understand that they need to be better at talking to customers. That's the message I put across today. What does Michael have to do? You have to focus on lead generation right now and not so much the engine. I know the engine's important and it can probably make the lead generation better, but we've been waiting for months. So, like I know posting and and coming up with creative stuff. I just did a post on LinkedIn. I spend every month at the beginning of the month inviting 250 people to follow Straw. Um, last month we only got 36. That was one of our lowest months. Usually I get like 50 or 60 of them. So, I

think I'm running out of people to invite.

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Vinnie Micciche: You know what I mean? I got 10,000 people to invite because like I want an audience.

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: LinkedIn is the place I have it. I mean, s***, I told Ken a year and a half ago, bro, our freaking uh our Facebook and Instagram. Figure out a way to do that. Like, to me, that's more important than anything is having an audience first, you know?

Michael Donovan: Heat. So, it's it's definitely, you know, there's a lot to be said about the people. And what I mean by that is like people are going to be more inclined to follow you, to listen to you, to engage with your posts than than they are with Strain.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah.

Michael Donovan: Look, I don't like that any more than you do, but we we can capitalize on that. Like your audience is double what Strawlet is, right? So I think if we can make any modification that would put us stepping in the right direction, it would be to have the strawid post that high level to low level

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Vinnie Micciche: Heat.

Michael Donovan: whatever man. Like we we'll be diverse with it and we'll tell the story but

Vinnie Micciche: another thing I talked about on the call which does relate to to marketing is that I'm doing my best to eliminate the busy work so we can we can focus on the important work and and this is something maybe I don't know if everyone thinks I'm crazy uh but I definitely have a vision And unfortunately, I'm not sure you're spending enough time really listening or hearing what I'm saying because it's not always translating into the messaging the right way. Like I know we're a BDC, but like one of the things you just pulled up is 47 minutes is too long. I wouldn't even waste my time talking about lead response anymore. There's so much more to talk about. You know what I mean? And then Z was doing that the week before. And that might have come, you might push back at me and say, "Well, that came from the the information you sent over."

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Vinnie Micciche: When I send over information, I'm trying to stimulate your thoughts and your your creativity. I'm not telling you necessarily. Now, with Z, I told him specifically, use what I what I sent. So, I wouldn't be complaining to Z if he he did that. But like, we're talking we have all these conversations, leadership calls. I'm sending documentation over left and right on all these things and ideas I have. We need to be able to formulate those into into messaging. And I think that's the important part of of marketing. It's your brand and your message. And I told Z. I told Yeah.

Michael Donovan: Yeah, you're talking like this one. Go ahead.

Vinnie Micciche: I told Z that. I said, "Listen, it's velocity, brand guidelines, messaging, and leads. That's what I focus on." You could argue with me till you're blue in the face. You know, that's how I've run my business. And I determine whether we're going to have a good or a bad month based on the leads that are coming through.

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Vinnie Micciche: And you know, I'm not saying your engine won't produce leads. It's just if you don't have the right messaging, it it won't. I mean, just go look at the post I just did today. It was about I've been really researching the s*** out of like where all this stuff and automotive going. And it basically told me here's why you need to be in in in place. LLMs, these are the 15 things that LLMs aren't going to answer for customers. It's going to help customers.

Michael Donovan: So yeah, so the these posts like this particular one that you pointed out would be Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: It's not going to sell them cars. You know what I mean? It's not book appointments for them.

Michael Donovan: It's it's just part of the story.

Vinnie Micciche: Listen, I'm I'm going to be happy with with whatever goes out as long as something's going out at the moment.

Michael Donovan: All right.

Vinnie Micciche: I just want it to be relevant to where we're headed and what we're thinking about.

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Vinnie Micciche: That's what I want. I want to see. And it might be too much to ask you, you know, because I know like Joe and I kind of had it out back and forth on an idea I had because he told me, you know, that could take two to five years to pull off. And I'm like, "Yeah, but you got to start somewhere." Like my idea between being that middleware between the LLMs and the dealers, I what I found was there's an absolute gap there that needs to be filled by somebody. Why not why not us?

Michael Donovan: right?

Vinnie Micciche: Maybe it is too big of an idea, but that's a hundred million idea. You understand?

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: If you can if you can translate C or you can hand off customers to dealerships from the LLMs, that's what the LLM's need.

Michael Donovan: Well, I think we're going to see ads in the LLMs as well.

Vinnie Micciche: Oh, no. They It said that and it said it said because I've been saying Google's in trouble and my buddies were pushing back on me when I was down in Florida with them and now I agree that they're not in

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Michael Donovan: Yeah. Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: trouble because of what J C Chad GPT told me. They already have a whole pipeline of customers. They just had to shift from Google to Gemini, you know.

Michael Donovan: Yeah. Yeah. There's no way Google is going down, man.

Vinnie Micciche: No, but my point my point is I thought that the LLM would take a chunk out of them, but um because they are it's just a matter of whether the the population adopts Gemini over Chat GBT and Claude.

Michael Donovan: Not Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: That would be how they go down. Um because, you know, frankly, you don't have to use Google anymore. My son told me, my Jake, who I ask a lot of questions, he's 21 years old.

Michael Donovan: Yep.

Vinnie Micciche: He doesn't even use Google anymore.

Michael Donovan: There's a percentage, right? It's uh I don't really It depends.

Vinnie Micciche: Don't use it anymore. I mean, I do a little, but not as much as I used to, but I have I have this knack.

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Michael Donovan: I mean, yes, there are times where I I Google something, but it's just way more accessible when you have the right LLM in history.

Vinnie Micciche: You just have to trust me on this. When I feel something, I'm excited about it. And it takes it's it doesn't happen often, but this is one of those moments in time. This is a big paradigm shift. It's very much a lot of disruptions about to happen, and I'm excited for it. Most people get scared of it, but I need a team around me that gets excited with me and can attack these LLMs with that 10 pages of, you know, stuff and get our website cranking and not wait, you know, one page at a time. Like, let's just if I can build it, if I can build 10 pages in an hour, you know, what's left to do to to you know what I'm saying? You say it's complex. I get it. But like, how That's something you told me.

Michael Donovan: No, but the Yeah.

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Michael Donovan: So, the content isn't the issue. Like, um I have a count here. The content isn't the issue. Yeah, we have right here, man. I mean, there we have 1,677 atomic content units, 23 hub pages, 120 spoke pages, and 24 clusters. So, and I already have that queued up in JSON. So if we you said it earlier, you want a a chatbot on the Straw website or an internal resource all about the company.

Vinnie Micciche: to train. Yeah, we'd have to train it. But that that that see again that would be important but not urgent, you know.

Michael Donovan: No, I I agree. But I'm not going to take that content and put all that work into it without doing that last like little 2%. I mean it was it was nominal to get it situated for that for the future. Um so and we Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: as we're talking about it, right? What I'm thinking of instead of asking a question about Strolled, we put Straw GPT up there and let dealers play with it the way we're going to put it on a dealer site.

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Vinnie Micciche: Like that would be cool.

Michael Donovan: I Well, you know what's Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: And it' be quicker.

Michael Donovan: So I I kind of have that outline for a lead magnet, right? They can have this this conversation. They can use the GPT

Vinnie Micciche: Forget about those great ideas. That's like your ice box, as Matt calls it. What can we do today to start hammering away? And even if it's not as exciting a work that we can start driving better traffic to our website and or creating, you know, better um lead magnets uh that don't require a lot of heavy lift to start generating,

Michael Donovan: Right.

Vinnie Micciche: you know, more better content, more questions. Leave leave the question to the to the dealer so they want to call us to find out more kind of stuff. Like that's the kind of stuff that I'm interested in right now because you get me conversations, we're going to sell right now. We're not getting conversations.

Michael Donovan: Right. So, I just want to kind of close it.

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Vinnie Micciche: And I'm not believe what I tell you. I don't believe the social posts are the end all beall, but at least it's something.

Michael Donovan: Okay. So, let's clo I want to close that loop real quick.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah.

Michael Donovan: Um, so I just threw the caption in here and I took the time to do these in Figma because there's another part of Figma where I wouldn't say it's fully automated, but the ability to iterate is it it's just way faster. And this was over Z's head, so there's a lot of efficiency. I know this is pretty basic, but hopefully you like it. uh you know creative wise we didn't start as a tech company we started on the showroom floor then drive the leading AI innovation conversational data to help dealers sell more right that's what's important to them and I think

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah.

Michael Donovan: it's also what's important to you know what that's and yeah all right well we can get into that in the cap options like these go hand.

Vinnie Micciche: How are they?

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Vinnie Micciche: But how are they going to sell more? No, but that's thinking as a dealer. I just I'm just being honest with you. You may not see that's exactly what I'm talking about. You You have to respect the I know you worked in the dealership, but I I I worked not only at a dealership, but I did do e-commerce and I talked to way more general managers than anybody when it comes to their business. And one of the biggest problems we have as a business is that um we these these guys turn over.

Michael Donovan: Okay.

Vinnie Micciche: Why? Because they're month-to-month guys. They're not long-term thinkers. Um so what what you're going to do to capture their attention, especially the ones that need help, is how are you going to help them sell more cars so they can hit their number every month so they can keep their job. I hate to say it that way, but that's that's currently the dealer types of dealers we're attracting. Um because we can scale there.

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Vinnie Micciche: The groups we can scale, they think a little differently. They think more long term and I get it and that would resonate with them. We have to we have to understand the persona of what we're trying to attract at the moment. And right now I need fast quick revenue, right? Because we lost a lot of business and that's where it's come from. It hasn't come from the groups. The groups are a different type of sale, you know, but I wanted to create a page so we could start looking, you know, start figuring out how do we penetrate the the bigger groups, you know, like for example,

Michael Donovan: Yeah, that

Vinnie Micciche: Asbury group one, Lithia is one of our customers. um Asbury Group One, um whatever name them, they have all kinds of b***** to get into their their company to sell to them.

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: And then, you know, like Lithia right now, it we're almost like we're in their like marketplace of vendors, but they look at us like, "Oh, I need help this month. I

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Vinnie Micciche: can turn Straw on and then shut them off next month when I hire somebody." Like that's it. It's not even a good the type of business we do is is I guess what I'm saying currently today is for the smaller mediumsiz um dealership groups um not the big ones because they need their help.

Michael Donovan: Yeah. And and they're the ones that that are retainable like they're they're going to make a change. They're not as you know they're getting good service, good results, everything's what as expected or better. I mean, I've had some really, really strong relationships with those, you know, 10, 12, 15 and under, um, groups, the followers, Joe Coopers, younger, you know, Patkin. I mean, I cut my teeth with Ralph Perkins in in 2007, man.

Vinnie Micciche: I I you know all that about you. We all I'm trying to say is like when it comes to AI, let's just tell them what it is.

Michael Donovan: So,

Vinnie Micciche: Let's just tell them what it is and what we do. How does it solve a problem?

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Vinnie Micciche: Don't just leave it vague or im ambiguous. Tell them how it solves the problem. You know what I mean? Like stop like this one below. Go to the next one. Stop treating customer uh stop treating customer calls as audio files. I don't know any dealer that would go what is that that understands what you mean by that. Um start treating them as valuable data. I like that part. Um and I think we need to start doing the data. But who treats customer calls as audio files? like meaning I I I just I guess the more I say it, the more I'm starting to understand what you mean. But Operation Street calls as emperorical moments.

Michael Donovan: listening to calls. Like we could say something along those lines. Stop listening to calls.

Vinnie Micciche: Like stop using words like that. We're talking to car guys. Do you know what I mean? Like you you are a smart guy. You got to kind of dumb it down a little bit.

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Vinnie Micciche: Just tell them what it is. I talk to them all the time. I would never use the word ephemeral.

Michael Donovan: Ephemeral ephemeral moment.

Vinnie Micciche: Never. Ever. No. Never. You're way above their pay grade when it comes to that. And that's not always a good thing, Michael. You know, you are educated. You can use words like that. But you we're talking to people. That's messaging. Would you ever use that word in with your friends when you're talking to them?

Michael Donovan: some of them. Sure. But yeah, I get your point. I'll tone it down, man.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah, we need to we need to talk to they're car guys.

Michael Donovan: I'll tone it down.

Vinnie Micciche: I've spent way too much time with them to know what they want to hear. They're very direct. They're very in your face. They want to know. They don't want to read a lot. They want to know what the hell you do and what can you solve their problem for really quick.

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Michael Donovan: I know what's scary is that allegedly came from the content of our website.

Vinnie Micciche: It doesn't even have to be whatever that that was.

Michael Donovan: I I know.

Vinnie Micciche: Most of that content was built to just to track search, you know what I mean? Not to I never thought anyone would read it all.

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: They type in ferical or whatever the hell you put in and I don't even know how to pronounce it. That's a problem if I can't pronounce it and I don't know what it means. I'm not that I'm pretty intelligent. Oh, so then just say for years BDC operations treated calls as a flash in the pan or a quick, you know what I mean?

Michael Donovan: It's just like a flash in the pan. That's all.

Vinnie Micciche: Or whatever. Like just say what it is. Once the phone hung up, the data was lost in a black box or a few type notes in the CRM. Like you're trying to tell a story here. I get it.

00:36:50

Vinnie Micciche: I just don't believe people are reading the story. Like what are you trying to get at? What are you trying to say here? Like you you should be writing, you know, so you know non-fiction books or fictional books I should say because you do writing story.

Michael Donovan: So, So, let's just But we're we're we're telling them how we solved the problem.

Vinnie Micciche: I just want to tell them what we're trying to tell them. Yeah, but it's too long. How did we solve the problem?

Michael Donovan: I mean, yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: Can you sum it up in three sentences? How we solve the problem? We turned your conversations into data and we made it searchable. You can search keywords 1, two, three, four. Spell it out. This is also important for you when you hire a new person and you train them because you're way up here and most people need like you to come down here to bring them up there. Not try to f***** get them to like, you know, you're telling the story like they're following along like they're, you know, English majors from Harvard or something like f*** that.

00:37:56

Vinnie Micciche: They're not. None of them, most of them didn't even go to college. That's why they went to the car business. because they could make a s*** ton of money without a college degree. You know that just say what it is.

Michael Donovan: Yeah. Yeah, I do know that.

Vinnie Micciche: You know, 47 minutes is too long to wait for a response. The average response times I mean that's like I don't even know if that's accurate. That might be old data. But to me, I'm going to look at that and go, "Well, my response time is 20 minutes or under, so I don't know what the hell they're talking about. There must be some pretty f***** up dealers out there, but it's not me." you're not getting my attention from this one. I I think most dealers respond pretty fast. Now, whether or not it's quality response is a different story or they're calling, texting, and emailing like we do, you know, at the same time. I I just don't think that's going to get me interested in Charlotte again.

00:38:53

Michael Donovan: So this is again this is really good information because it's all coming from the content on currently on our I'm sorry.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm. But I wanted I didn't want you to do this. I wanted you to do something creative, say what it is, and then we could have a conversation about it or pick out the stuff you want to use and send it to me before you go through all this work because I'm just I'm throwing a s*** ton at you guys. I did that as a point of of of of like here's some statistical stuff. If we're going to use statistics, let's back it up with, you know, something that we can reference. You know what I mean? Like statistics do sell, but this just says 47 minutes is too long. It doesn't tell me uh it doesn't tell me what that means. 47 minutes is too long.

Michael Donovan: for, you know, for a customer to wait for to receive a Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: But it doesn't say that, Michael. And it doesn't say where that number came from.

00:39:56

Vinnie Micciche: It doesn't say that it's, you know, this is an autotrader f*****.com stat that says the average dealer is at f***** 47 minutes. It just says 47 minutes is too long.

Michael Donovan: Again, I'm I'm using So, I took I took our content and I put it into a notebook. I'll share it with you right now.

Vinnie Micciche: I know. But there is parts of this that we need to use our common sense. That's all. And think about it. Every time I do something or I when I'm selling or when I'm talking to dealers or when I'm trying to come up with ideas for marketing, I I try to think of if I'm the dealer, how do I, you know, how am I um, you know, absorbing that information? Like, how does it hit me? So, what I'm telling you is 47 minutes is too long to wait for response. I don't know really. I assume you're talking about lead response. But I don't know.

Michael Donovan: Yeah, I we're probably not going to go with this one, right?

00:41:03

Michael Donovan: So,

Vinnie Micciche: No, I just think that that's kind of like BDC from 2012. You know what I

mean? Respond fast. Like they they hear that enough. What are we doing that's, you know, different? And I like where you're going with the other one, but I just you have to spell it out for me. So I understand like you understand what we're doing here. I understand what we're doing here. I can look at this. You know, Lei Miranville was one of my mentors. He was like one of the best trainers I've ever met in my life and he did all the training for the East Coast for a group one sales training and he was a master in neurallinguistic psychology. He and I used to have great conversations and he taught me a lot and and one time he gave me a personality profile like a real high level psychologybacked f***** university backed psych psych test and what he told me was that I have this very unique ability to um understand my point of view understand the po person I'm speaking to's point of view but he said based on the the outcome of the the test it said that I have this ability to take myself out of that and see it from a third person.

00:42:14

Vinnie Micciche: And he said, "Not many people have that ability." That's what he told me I have. That's my gift that God gave me, I suppose. And when I'm talking to you and me, I'm also thinking like the dealer right now. And I don't know if I just assume everybody does that.

Michael Donovan: Yeah, I think we have like we have some fundamental differences on our belief of the ICP. Um, like, well, I know, but it can't go the other way.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah. And I think you have to get over that. You have to trust me.

Michael Donovan: Like, I Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: Not right now. It's not working. Right now, nothing's working. So, we need to try my way. If your way was working, believe me, like I said to Joe when he was telling me about all the things he wanted to work with Jason on. I'm like, Jason's selling his ass off right now. Leave him the f*** alone. If you if you were driving leads in here like crazy, I would f***** back right off.

00:43:11

Vinnie Micciche: But believe me, I've been working at this company for 12 years. You've been here for a year. I know what was working. So, trust me. Or get it working because it's not.

Michael Donovan: Yeah. Well, to Jason's point or here's Say that again.

Vinnie Micciche: I do believe I do believe messaging has a lot to do with it. I believe messaging has a lot to do with it.

Michael Donovan: Messaging definitely has a lot to do with it. And uh you know we we have to we have to increase our reach and and volume no

Vinnie Micciche: Right. But let me ask you a question. So, are you saying that your fundamental difference on how I approach messaging to how you do that you're right, you believe you're right and I'm wrong? Is that what you're So what what is different?

Michael Donovan: not about messaging about about our about the dealer like we just have different experiences Um I' I've seen deal like as you know reporting and and

Vinnie Micciche: What's your different?

00:44:12

Vinnie Micciche: What do you see different between our experiences?

Michael Donovan: you know data and information um you know my my experience with that is you know if if it's of high quality and relevancy that they they're all in on it.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah. What about?

Michael Donovan: It's like the the state If there's if they have trust in it, therefore being you know high quality, accurate.

Vinnie Micciche: What do you mean by high quality and relevancy? How do you deter How do you say that mine doesn't provide that and yours does? Your your perspective. What am I doing?

Michael Donovan: No. So, so my understanding, I don't want to put words in your mouth, but again, this is my perception, which isn't always real, is that I've seen dealers

Vinnie Micciche: Yep.

Michael Donovan: dive into dashboards and data and make decisions on it and

Vinnie Micciche: What What is that? Why is that different than what I'm saying compared to what you're saying then? So 47 minutes is too long is what we're talking about to wait for a response that I don't like.

00:45:27

Vinnie Micciche: I don't from a dealer perspective, I don't really understand how why I need to call Straw if I'm at a 20% response time because I stare at data and reporting all

day.

Michael Donovan: Okay. So, I I wasn't specifically talking about the 47 minutes. I was making a statement about my understanding and experience of of dealers and what they're after. And I I think that's also a point of contention.

Vinnie Micciche: What are they after, Michael?

Michael Donovan: Um and and

Vinnie Micciche: Michael, show me some creative. I You're using stuff that I put in a document over a month ago. Um, I've been sending you lots and lots and tons and tons and tons of information. You know, I'll give you how I use AI. We have a email chain going back with Sutherland for a month now. Back and forth, back and forth with Eric, with Brett Sutherland, with Link and me. And and a couple times I snapped at Brett because I I didn't like his tone towards Link and and us.

00:46:33

Vinnie Micciche: And uh I basically sent an email today and I said, "Listen, we're going to just shut you off today because you haven't responded since my last email and I told you I wasn't going to charge you for no November. It's it's December 2nd, blah blah blah." Well, they're their VP of of operations sent me an email and called me and said, "Call me right away." So, I did. He's a group one guy. He knows Jeremy Smith who works for Southerntherland. I didn't know, which is a friend of mine. Anyway, he says, "You know, Jeremy says you're you're a good guy and I've seen these emails going back and forth and I just don't understand what the heck's going on." I said, "Listen, I can do I can do I I I'll get you all the information you need. We got a call tomorrow. He wants to patch it up. He doesn't want us to shut him off." blah blah blah. I took all that whole email.

00:47:19

Vinnie Micciche: I copied the whole thing from the first email to the last. I put it in chatt say, "Give me a chronological breakdown of of of how this whole thing played out." And it did in two seconds. How long would that have taken me before? That's what I use AI for is like, how do I get things done faster? And so, I'm producing as much content as I possibly can. I'm not telling you that you absolutely have to use every little thing that I use, but the stuff I've seen hasn't been your uh what you're saying, which is data driven, dashboard driven type content out there that you think dealers I mean, Ken was

producing most of the content. I don't even know if you were approving some of that stuff, but it was very wordy and very long.

Michael Donovan: I

Vinnie Micciche: And now, you know, Z's sending me stuff that I'm just like scratching my head going, "What the hell are we doing?" And now you're showing me some content today that I just don't typ part particularly like.

00:48:15

Vinnie Micciche: So I just want us to get on the same page. That's all. So when you say that we're different, you're not explaining to me how we're different.

Michael Donovan: so I want to see the data like will this work?

Vinnie Micciche: Specific.

Michael Donovan: Well, I don't I just I don't think this is um like this set, right?

Vinnie Micciche: What data?

Michael Donovan: And and of course, we can Okay.

Vinnie Micciche: How they make this? Who did I wouldn't have put text inside a box and then put text next to it. I have some flashy freaking eyecatching.

Michael Donovan: No, Vin Vin, this is the caption, man.

Vinnie Micciche: I know.

Michael Donovan: That's the caption.

Vinnie Micciche: No, but the creative is just text in a box.

Michael Donovan: That's not part of the graphic. This is text in a box is what you're saying.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah, it's text inside a box.

Michael Donovan: Okay. Okay.

Vinnie Micciche: There's no there's no um statistics or numbers or pictures or anything in there. You're making me read twice.

00:49:16

Michael Donovan: No, the the the numbers the numbers are on the performance of of of doing the set.

Vinnie Micciche: Michael, here's the thing.

Michael Donovan: That's all I'm saying.

Vinnie Micciche: Here's here's what I'm going to tell you. I've been around a lot of marketing people. A lot. Your messaging isn't great. Let me do it. Just show give me some I'm giving you ideas. Put something together quick, simple, not wordy, not long, not something I got to read. Something that gets my attention. That's what I want. It's that simple. Seriously, I mean, my posts are long because I'm talking I'm I'm actually explaining something, one specific thing, and people read it. I've already gotten, you know, a couple likes and a comment on something I posted today. But my point is with us, I want to look at it and go, "Hm, that's intriguing. What the hell do they mean by that? Oh, what are they doing with conversational intelligence? What what do they mean by dealer MRI?" You

00:50:16

Vinnie Micciche: know, or or dealer brain or whatever. Like I want to It's what?

Michael Donovan: So that like do you want to you want to that's what I asked yesterday and I it it wasn't clear like yeah I I was on the executive leadership uh meeting man but to take the the whole meeting

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah. Yeah.

Michael Donovan: we can run it through the sufficient.

Vinnie Micciche: Yeah. You can run it through anything.

Michael Donovan: It's great. I think what what wasn't what still what do you mean?

Vinnie Micciche: I don't think you I think you don't like it. I think you think you're better than the LLMs, which I gave up on. It's way better than I am.

Michael Donovan: No way, V. I don't

Vinnie Micciche: I can take I can take that whole entire conversation and dump it into an LLM and it's going to spit out messaging and and and and go to market strategies and all that. I don't have f***** time for that, Michael. It's beautiful. Now I can now I have a I have it all summarized for myself and I can read through it quickly and I can add my own flare to it.

00:51:16

Vinnie Micciche: I like speed. You don't, buddy. like you you you're like one of these like artists that want to f***** paint the Mona Lisa and I'm I don't want to do that. I don't have time for that. I'm not gonna sit there all f***** day long when I know I can spit

something out that looks like the Mona Lisa, but might be missing a couple little bones there here and there or something. I'm all about speed, buddy.

Michael Donovan: Yeah. Um, right on I'm a huge fan of speed and velocity and and impact.

Vinnie Micciche: It's gotten me this far. I can't be I can't be totally wrong with my my approach. So why are you saying you're saying you would you almost gonna insult me kind of saying what do you mean you're are smarter than that?

Michael Donovan: I'm not trying to slow anything down, Vin.

Vinnie Micciche: Why would you rely on LLMs instead of using your own brain?

Michael Donovan: I didn't say I then I'm No. No. The opposite.

Vinnie Micciche: You were about to say that.

00:52:20

Vinnie Micciche: What were you going to say?

Michael Donovan: The opposite. I I'm right there with you, Vinn. I'm right there with you. I promise you. I'm I'm I'm deep, man, in in AI utilization.

Vinnie Micciche: Okay.

Michael Donovan: Okay. and and there are ways that we can definitely gain speed. Okay. What's a little frustrating is that it it just this guy hung out way too long.

Vinnie Micciche: Mhm.

Michael Donovan: All right. And I could care less what he says or thinks about me because I gave him f***** hund times more than I ever gave anyone running my own company or working in another agency or building a team at LEA or Lazeri or anywhere else that I worked. Not my first rodeo ramping somebody or even interviewing somebody. He interviewed great, answered all the questions, gave me all the confidence.

Vinnie Micciche: Whatever.

Michael Donovan: So,

Vinnie Micciche: See, that's the other thing. So, just so you know, there's something inside of me like, you know, I'm going through a divorce, right?

00:53:42

Vinnie Micciche: The minute my wife decided that she wanted a divorce and then asked

me to move, she's done. I I don't When people leave me, they're done. They're gone. But when they're here, I'm all in. And I'm 100% the best person you want on your f***** side. But I I Z's already gone. Forget Let's stop talking about him. Ken's gone.

Michael Donovan: Okay. It I I was just Okay.

Vinnie Micciche: We brought We broughtina back because she left on good ter terms. You know what I mean? Like let's move forward here. I want to play this for you real quick.

Michael Donovan: So,

Vinnie Micciche: Let me play this for you real quick. This is Bezos talking. Forward quickly on on decisions. as quickly as as you responsibly can is how you increase velocity. Most of what slows things down is in is taking too long to make decisions at all skill levels, you know. So, it has to be part of the culture to get high velocity.

00:54:38

Vinnie Micciche: You know, Amazon has a million and a half people and the company is still fast. We're still decisive. We're still quick. And that's because the culture supports that decisiveness. Decisiveness. I feel like I'm in quicksand with marketing the last four months and I don't know why. And I know and I gave you a bonus for helping out Viconic and we still don't have a website. Like I and I know that's not your fault, but I'm like just saying like if I were in your position in in your position with the company, I'd be like a f***** cage tiger. You bet your ass freaking Perry would hear from me and Vinwood about I can't. this guy needs to make a f***** decision and I'm not doing another thing for him until he comes to me with very clear expectations because I got s*** to do. That's how I work. And people don't like it because I'm loud and I'm in your face and I'm direct. But I don't sit here.

00:55:34

Vinnie Micciche: They don't sit back. I get s*** f***** done. And that's the culture we we have here. We got to get s*** done. We can't be like making excuses or blaming Z or whatever. Like whatever. I get it. I'm not beating you up because of Z. I'm the one who told you to give him a little bit more time because I thought maybe if I set really f***** extremely clear expectations he would change. He didn't. I moved f***** fast after I realized the second he didn't do what I needed him to do, he was gone. You notice that

because I was so clear with him.

Michael Donovan: Yeah, right.

Vinnie Micciche: I was so f***** crystal clear with that kid. I couldn't have been more crystal clear with him. He needed to go. He was a problem. We kind of knew that three weeks ago. I needed to prove it because I didn't feel comfortable with what you were telling me and versus what he was telling me.

00:56:28

Vinnie Micciche: You know, may you know, all you have to do, right, is just say, "Here's here's uh a plan this week. This is what I'm going to execute on." And I might say, "Can you can you take this out and move that in there? Or can you show me the content before it goes out?" Yes. Boom. We're we're good. We're in we're in business. You got a plan you're executing on. I just want to make sure it's being executed on. And and that's what I'm saying. When I don't know what you're doing, I don't know what you're doing. And if you need my help with Perry, I told you two months ago, stop working on Viconic stuff and start working on Stalled. And you neglected to tell me that you committed to this website thing. But man, that was like early September. We're in December. That's not fast enough for me. That was early December we had that conversation. I said, "Finish the f***** website and then get on to Straw and it's still not done."

00:57:31

Vinnie Micciche: I mean, I think you need to take some responsibility in that or set some f***** borders and guidelines for Perry and say, "This is what I can do for you. I'll build you a website. Get me everything you want, exactly the way you want it, and then I'll build it. That's what I would say to him. Otherwise, leave me the hell alone because I'm busy. He's a human f***** being. He's not anything special. He's not driving revenue in here right now. He's not doing anything that would make me worry about Perry leaving if you were hard on him or something. And I'm not going to push back on you if you have logical reasons for pushing on him. You know what I mean? I wouldn't sit there and deal with that.

Michael Donovan: Look, man, it you know, I hear you. Um

Vinnie Micciche: But it's the same thing with Ken. Like you let Ken hang on here for like seven long months longer than we needed to.

00:58:18

Vinnie Micciche: I made the decision on Ken. I made I fired Z. Like it's okay. I don't mind. It's just start like making decisions and moving to, you know, making it happen. If they're not right, f***** be make show you're crystal clear as to why he's not working. That's what I did. I set expectations. I wrote them down. I had him repeat them four times. And when he was on the call, I was like, "Dude, I told you velocity, brand guideline, messaging, and leads are you you you send me something on Monday and then I have to hear from Michael late Wednesday that nothing went out this week. That's unacceptable." Whoa, whoa, Michael told me not to send it to you. Whatever. That's That's unacceptable.

Michael Donovan: All

Vinnie Micciche: I also told you I have an open door policy. You can call me anytime and communicate with me. I'm o I'm an open book. I'm an open door. You can and you know that.

00:59:13

Vinnie Micciche: I told you that. So, I'm not buying it.

Michael Donovan: right. So, here here's what I think we can do immediately. All right. We will get the flow. I'll I'll refine and and take another crack. And I have a couple other designs. So, I'll put all of those together with not the storytelling format, more in-your-face um lowfunnel, we'll say, right? Lead driving social post. But let's pick one thing. And and man, the VCON site, that's a separate topic. I will circle back with Perry and uh yeah, wait.

Vinnie Micciche: I know, but it's already the end of the day on Tuesday and we don't have posts going out again. So, just send whatever you got.

Michael Donovan: We're going to we're going to get

Vinnie Micciche: Put something to go out there. But see, that's the part you miss in you miss from me is speed decisions. Just do something because we got nothing. We have no post. That's why I did one today because I didn't even know if you were still going to be working for us on this freaking phone call based on how you reacted to me earlier.

01:00:23

Vinnie Micciche: Like I need f***** s*** out there, dude. I got to stand on my head and scream 50 times. Send one of them. The best one. I don't care what it is. I want to see that happening. No. Do you understand what I mean, Michael?

Michael Donovan: Yeah, Van, I understand what you mean.

Vinnie Micciche: Tuesday night.

Michael Donovan: There's nothing I'm confused about with it.

Vinnie Micciche: It's Tuesday night and we have no going out again.

Michael Donovan: So, I know Vin and I'm I'm building astrology.

Vinnie Micciche: Last week we had nothing going out Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday. Now we got this week going out, we got nothing going out Monday, now Tuesday. It's like, what the f*** are we doing? It's like quicksand. It's like I'm like seriously sinking in quicksand over here. I don't give a f*** what you're building. I'm asking This is where we we we dis this is where we completely disagree with each other. I don't give a f*** what you're building.

01:01:09

Vinnie Micciche: I'm asking for something very simple and it doesn't get done. Get some f***** ex something out there, a new an email, a f***** post. I don't give a s*** what it is. Just send one of those things. I don't care what you're building. I don't right now. I don't care when you build it, it works, and the leads start coming in. But that ain't happening right now. So, can we please send a post out to LinkedIn and and and some places? So we like I just looked we haven't sent anything else since f***** Z left on Thursday or whatever it was Sunday.

Michael Donovan: Sunday.

Vinnie Micciche: Sunday he did. Yeah, because I told him to. I asked him where the hell was the um was the dialer. All right, listen. Here's what I'm going to do. Get something out there tonight. I will work on some ideas tonight and I will send you what I want sent out tomorrow, Wednesday or Thursday and you can put your own carousel thing together.

01:02:10

Vinnie Micciche: I I just I need something going out there. I would even take this 47 minutes even though it doesn't mean s***. It's better than it than uh Ken's f***** kid in a coconut patch. Um it's just not ideal. Like we got so much great stuff sitting here that we can do better than this. That's all I'm saying.

Michael Donovan: We have new stuff, right? That I I I just that's what wasn't clear if we're going to use the the dealer MRI and dealer brain verbiage or are were we trying to allude to the the benefit and the problem itself?

Vinnie Micciche: I know, but you don't really give it's new. Look it. Look it. The way I look at it is that screenshot I sent you on the dialer. We don't have that yet either.

Michael Donovan: Yeah.

Vinnie Micciche: The dealers don't need to know what the f*** we we have or what we don't have. They need to know that we're doing some f***** exciting new things. That's what they need to know.

01:03:06

Vinnie Micciche: And that they need to call us and find out what the f*** it is.

Michael Donovan: Heat.

Vinnie Micciche: That's what and our competitors should be s***** their pants when they hear about all the new stuff that we're doing. Not 47 minute minute f***** response time. That's that's so 2008. You know what I mean? That's what we were saying 12 years ago. That's all I'm saying. It's not getting my attention. So, I'll think it through. I mean, I I didn't want to have to I did send Listen, the last thing I sent you to, by the way, was over a month ago. I haven't even looked at it.

Michael Donovan: The last thing you sent was a month ago.

Vinnie Micciche: the content a page of cont.

Michael Donovan: I'm Yeah, they were right. The three three posts or whatever or you know, however you So, what I did like to to not create a bottleneck or a task for you, I took those three posts and that's

Vinnie Micciche: Let me see. Hold on.

Michael Donovan: what I was trying to get was a I I think a just a little more clarity yesterday on the on the specific topic and I can put it through the the process.

Transcription ended after 01:04:51

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